

HERE COMES THE SON Lokesh meets TDP supporters in Tirupati after becoming party's working president

> **"Our government's priority is rapid growth, job creation, and making AP a top investment target. For the TDP, it's all about grassroots organisation and staying connected to the people"**
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> **NARA LOKESH**
> *Working President, TDP; Andhra Pradesh minister*

painstaking transformation Lokesh has gone through since—both politically and in physical appearance. Gone are the stumbling, awkward speeches, and instead has emerged an authoritative leader, who is also a good orator.

Behind the transformation has been a conscious effort to rebuild a positive image. A foodie earlier, Lokesh shed some 30 kilos after the 2019 loss. A party strategist who worked with him recalls how during brainstorming sessions at the party office, "while all of us would be devouring pizzas during lunch breaks, Lokesh would be snacking on boiled vegetables". The strict diet regime, according to him, did wonders. Lokesh lost weight, but also became a political heavyweight. A workout warrior today, he sports a trim look and a salt-and-pepper stubble.

Lokesh, say political analysts, came into his own as a leader during the year-long Yuva Galam padayatra in 2023. The state-wide yatra on foot, from family bastion Kuppam to Ichchapuram, the northern tip of the state, covered 3,132 km. A TDP functionary who took part recalls, "He was still a haughty, city-bred boy, largely disconnected from the party leaders and cadre when it started, but by the end of the yatra, after the thousands of interactions with local people, he became much more compassionate in his approach."

GAINING SOME WORK EX

With several high-profile ministries under him, Lokesh has had his plate full since 2024. As IT, electronics and communications minister, he has made Visakhapatnam a key IT hub, competing with the likes of Bengaluru and Hyderabad. Besides the top prize, Google's $1.5 billion (Rs 1.41 lakh crore) AI hub, others like Infosys, TCS and Cognizant have all flocked here, taking advantage of the LIFT (Land Incentive for Tech hubs) policy unveiled in 2025. Among the sweeteners offered to attract globally reputed tech firms is the contentious offer of land at a nominal price of 99 paise per acre. The state, incidentally, accounted for a quarter of all the investment commitments coming to India in 2025-26.

Lokesh has also been leveraging tech to advance the state government's objectives in education, health and welfare. Mana-Mitra, a WhatsApp-based digital governance initiative launched last year, provides some 200 citizen services hassle-free.

The TDP minister is also in charge of CM Naidu's pet project, the RTG initiative. RTG involves real-time monitoring and action using data, satellite imagery and artificial intelligence, and has been a game-changer in several fields, from services delivery and information dissemination to agriculture advisories and extreme weather alerts. In fact, the TDP government is so chuffed by its success that a tour of the state-of-the-art RTG centre in capital Amaravati for visiting VIPs—the latest being Bill Gates—is now almost mandatory.

Under Lokesh, the TDP has also strengthened its welfare framework for party workers and their family members, including a Rs 5 lakh insurance cover, financial support for education, healthcare, and training and skill development programmes to improve employment prospects. In January